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Neuroinclusive education | Universal Design | **RSE & Me**

Relationships and sexuality education

RSE & Me

A guide for parents, caregivers and teachers

An Autism & Me product

Version 1.0 | 31 October 2026

www.autismandme.ie

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Contents

Welcome....3
Why talk early?....5
Ages and stages....6
Puberty planning....13
Keeping children safe....15
Online safety....19
Autistic children and young people....22
Diversity: orientation and gender identity....25
Consent, relationships and the law....27
RSE in Irish schools....30
Tips for talking....32
Supports and services in Ireland....34
Templates you can edit....36

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Welcome

Talking to children about bodies, feelings, friendships and growing up can feel daunting. Many of us were given very little information when we were young. Many of us were told to wait until we were older, or told nothing at all. This guide is here to make it easier.

It is written for parents, grandparents, foster and kinship carers, teachers, SNAs and anyone else who spends time with a child. You do not need to be an expert. You only need to be willing to listen, to be calm and to be honest at the child's level.

Lots of little conversations, not one big talk

There is no single moment when a child must be "told everything". Children learn a little at a time, and they learn all the time. They pick things up from the bath, the school bus, a song on the radio, a storyline on television and the games on a tablet.

Short, regular chats work better than one long, awkward sit-down. Small chats let a child take in one idea, think about it and come back with a question. They also show a child that these topics are normal and that you are a safe person to ask.

TRY THIS

- Use ordinary moments: bath time, a car journey, getting dressed, a pregnancy in the family, a character on a programme.
- Say one thing, then stop. Leave space for a question.
- If you get stuck, say "Good question. Let me think and we will talk about it later." Then do come back to it.

What does "sexuality" cover?

When adults hear the word sexuality they often think only of sex. In relationships and sexuality education, it covers much more. It begins in the first days of life and it includes:

- **Bodies:** the correct names for body parts, how bodies work and how they change.
- **Feelings:** love, affection, crushes, worries, embarrassment and joy.
- **Relationships:** family, friends, partners, and how to treat people and be treated.
- **Boundaries and consent:** who may touch us, when, and how to say yes, no or "not now".
- **Identity:** who we are, who we are drawn to and how we see our gender.
- **Safety:** staying safe in person and online, and knowing who to tell.
- **Values:** what matters to your family, your faith or your ethos, and why.

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All kinds of families

Children grow up in many kinds of homes. Some live with two parents, some with one. Some are raised by grandparents, by foster carers, by kinship carers or by a mix of adults who share the care. Some families have two mums or two dads. Some children move between homes.

Every one of these adults can have these conversations. You do not need to be a child's birth parent to be a trusted adult. If you are a carer, you may be starting from a place where a child has already had hard experiences. Go gently, keep routines steady and know that you can ask for help from the child's social worker, the school or your GP.

How to use this guide

You can read it from start to finish or dip into the parts you need. The sections on ages and stages are designed to be used again and again as your child grows. The section on autistic children and young people is for everyone, because many of its ideas make teaching clearer for all learners. Look out for these boxes:

TRY THIS

- Practical ideas you can use straight away.

AUTISM TIP

- Adaptations that help many autistic children and young people. They are often helpful for other children too.

WORDS TO USE

- Simple, accurate wording you can borrow or change to suit your family.

The templates at the end are editable. Print them, fill them in on screen or copy them into your own notes.

This guide gives general information and ideas. It is not legal, medical or counselling advice.

A note on language

We say "autistic child" and "autistic young person" because many autistic people prefer identity-first language. Some families prefer other words. Please use whatever words your child chooses. We talk about barriers in environments, not deficits in children. Our approach is based on Universal Design for Learning (UDL): when we change the environment and the way we teach, more children can take part without having to fit in first.

Why talk early?

Many adults worry that talking early will "put ideas in a child's head". The evidence from experience is the reverse. Children who have accurate, calm information tend to be better prepared, not more curious in unhelpful ways. Here are eight reasons to start early.

1. **Children are already learning.** If you do not offer information, they will find it elsewhere, and the source may be a friend, a screen or a playground rumour that is wrong or frightening.
2. **It builds trust.** A child who learns that you answer questions calmly will keep asking as they get older. That matters most when the questions get harder.
3. **It helps keep them safe.** A child who knows the correct names for their body and knows that their body belongs to them is better able to say when something is not right.
4. **It makes puberty less of a shock.** Knowing what is coming means a body change is a plan, not an emergency.
5. **It takes the embarrassment out.** If body words are used from the start, they are just words. Silence is what makes a topic feel awkward.
6. **It supports good relationships.** Early lessons about kindness, respect, personal space and listening to "no" are the foundations of healthy relationships later.
7. **It lets you share your values.** If you speak first, your child hears your view, your family's beliefs and your reasons before they hear anyone else's.
8. **It suits the way many children learn.** Many children, and especially many autistic children, need time, repetition and preparation. Starting early gives them that time.

TRY THIS

- Think of it like road safety. We do not wait until a teenager is driving before we talk about roads. We start at the kerb with a toddler and add a little more every year.

Reflecting on your own values

Before you talk to your child it helps to know what you think. Your values, beliefs and family traditions matter. So does the way you were raised. You may want to hand some things down and do some things differently.

School teaching sits alongside your voice. In Ireland, parents are the primary educators of their children. Your conversations at home are the main thread, and school lessons add to them.

Use the table below on your own or with your partner, co-parent or the other adults who care for your child. There are no right answers. The aim is to be clear in your own mind and to notice where you might need support.

Question to think about	My thoughts	Words or phrases I am comfortable using
What did I learn about bodies and relationships when I was growing up? What helped? What did I wish I had been told?		
What values do I most want my child to carry into their relationships? (For example kindness, respect, honesty, faith.)		
Which topics feel easy for me to talk about? Which feel hard?		
Do the adults in our child's life agree on the key messages? Where do we differ?		
Who else could help me if a question is beyond me?		
What do I want my child to know about consent and about saying no?		

Ages and stages

Children are individuals, and ages are only a rough guide. An eight-year-old may be ready for ideas that another eight-year-old will not need for a year. Many autistic children are very interested in some topics at an early age and still need extra time with others. Use the stages below as a map, and follow your own child's lead.

For every age, the same four ideas run through: my body is mine, there are correct names for body parts, I can say no and be listened to, and I can always tell a trusted adult anything.

Birth to 2 years

The first lessons are not spoken. They are about being held, fed, comforted and responded to.

What is typical

- Babies and toddlers explore their bodies, including their genitals. This is natural curiosity.
- They learn through touch, sound and routine whether the world is safe.

- Toddlers begin to say "no" and "mine" and to want to do things themselves.

What to teach

- Warm, responsive care. Answering a cry teaches trust.
- The correct names for body parts, said in the same tone as "elbow" or "knee".
- Respect for the child's "no" in small things, such as not wanting a hug from a relative.
- Telling the child what you are doing during nappy changes and washing: "I am going to wipe your bottom now."

WORDS TO USE

- "This is your penis." "This is your vulva." "These are your toes."
- "I am going to change your nappy now. Ready?"
- "You do not want a hug? That is okay. Would you like to wave instead?"

AUTISM TIP

- Keep routines for washing and dressing predictable and in the same order.
- Some babies and toddlers are very sensitive to touch, tags, water temperature and noise. Notice what is comfortable and adjust it.
- Use the same words every time and ask other carers to use them too.

2 to 5 years

These are the early years, and Aistear, the national early childhood curriculum framework, supports learning through play, relationships and communication. Everyday play is the best classroom.

What is typical

- Children are curious about everything, including where babies come from and why bodies are different.
- They may touch their genitals for comfort, undress in public or ask loud questions in the shop.
- They begin to understand private and public, though they will need many reminders.
- Play often includes "mammies and daddies", doctors and nurses and other pretend families.

What to teach

- The correct names for all body parts, including genitals.
- Simple ideas about private parts and private places: bathroom and bedroom are for private things.

- My body belongs to me. Nobody may touch my private parts, except to keep me clean or healthy, and then they ask and explain.
- Feelings words, and that all feelings are okay.
- Safe adults: who they are and that I can tell them anything.
- The difference between a secret and a surprise (see the section on keeping children safe).

WORDS TO USE

- "Your private parts are the parts covered by your swimsuit."
- "Babies grow in a part of the body called the uterus. It is inside the mother's body."
- "We do that in private, in the bathroom or in your bedroom."
- "If anyone ever makes you feel yucky or scared, tell me or another safe adult. You will never be in trouble for telling."

AUTISM TIP

- Use picture books and photographs rather than long explanations.
- Show private and public places with a simple visual, for example a photo of the bathroom labelled "private".
- If your child touches themselves in public, calmly and kindly say "That is for private. Let's go to your bedroom", rather than scolding. Shame does not help.
- Be literal. "Private parts" may confuse some children, so say plainly which parts and why.

5 to 9 years: Junior Infants to 2nd class

Children are in school and friendships matter more. They are asking more detailed questions.

What is typical

- Children ask where babies come from, how they get out and how they get in.
- They enjoy toilet humour and test words they have overheard. This is normal.
- They notice differences in bodies, families and gender and may compare themselves with others.
- They may hear half-truths from older children or from screens.
- Some children begin to feel shy about changing in front of others.

What to teach

- Basic facts about how babies are made, in simple, accurate terms.
- Body changes as part of growing, so that puberty is a familiar idea long before it starts.

- Friendship skills: taking turns, listening, saying no kindly and hearing no.
- Personal safety: private parts, safe and unsafe touch, trusted adults.
- Early online safety: asking a grown-up before clicking and telling an adult if something upsets them.
- That there are many kinds of families.

WORDS TO USE

- "A baby starts when a cell from a man's body, called a sperm, joins with a cell from a woman's body, called an egg."
- "Bodies change as children grow. That is called puberty. It happens to everyone, and it begins when you are older."
- "Those are words some people use as jokes. Here is what we say in our family."

AUTISM TIP

- Pre-teach vocabulary before school lessons. Ask the teacher or SET what is coming up and read the topic together first.
- Use real diagrams, simple books and clear photographs.
- Say clearly which words are for home and which are for friends. A rule such as "We do not use that word at school" is easier than "Use judgement".
- Practise answering the question "Where do babies come from?" so your child has a short, simple answer in case a classmate asks.

9 to 12 years: 3rd to 6th class

This is the time to get ahead of puberty. Many children begin to change at nine or ten, and some earlier.

What is typical

- Early puberty changes begin for some children. Others have not started and may feel left behind.
- Friendships become complex. Cliques, falling-out and exclusion are common.
- Children may get their first phone, game console or social media account, or be around friends who have.
- Crushes begin. Some children feel nothing yet, and that is fine too.
- Interest in privacy grows. A child may want a closed door.

What to teach

- The changes of puberty in all bodies, before they start (see the puberty planning section).
- Periods, wet dreams and hygiene routines, for every child, whatever their gender.

- How sex and pregnancy work, in clear, factual terms.
- Consent, respect and personal boundaries, including with friends and online.
- Online safety, including how to respond to unwanted contact and what to do if they see something upsetting.
- The fact that people can be attracted to people of any gender, and that all people deserve respect.

WORDS TO USE

- "Sex is one way two adults can show love and may be how a baby begins. It should only ever be something both people want and agree to."
- "Everyone's body changes at its own speed. Being early or late does not mean anything is wrong."
- "Your body, your privacy. Knock before you come in, and I will too."

AUTISM TIP

- Start the puberty plan early, using visuals and a timeline.
- Rehearse practical skills such as using a pad, putting dirty clothes in the wash and applying deodorant.
- Social stories can help with changing friendships and with new school routines.
- Check how your child understands the lessons they hear. Many autistic children repeat information correctly but find it hard to apply it in the moment.

Puberty: a note before the teenage years

Puberty is not a single event. It is a series of changes that can take several years. Hormones begin to change the body, the skin, the sleep pattern and the emotions. For some young people the first signs appear in the last years of primary school; for others it comes in post-primary.

You will find a full planning guide in its own section. The main message is this: tell children before it happens, and tell them what is normal, what is private and what help is available.

12 to 14 years: 1st and 2nd year

Young people enter post-primary school. This is a big transition in itself, with a new building, new routines and new people.

What is typical

- Puberty is well under way for many. Mood swings, tiredness and a need for privacy are all typical.

- Peer opinion becomes very important. Young people compare their bodies and are sensitive to teasing.
- Many have a phone and use social media or messaging, and friends may share things without thinking.
- Interest in romantic or sexual feelings grows, or in some cases does not, and both are normal.
- SPHE in Junior Cycle begins in 1st year.

What to teach

- How pressure works and how to say no, including to friends and partners.
- Respectful relationships, including what is and is not okay in a friendship or a first relationship.
- Consent, in everyday terms and in the law.
- How to use technology safely, including never sharing intimate images and what to do if someone asks.
- Reproductive health in factual terms, including sexual and menstrual health.
- Sexual orientation and gender identity in a respectful, factual way.

WORDS TO USE

- "You never have to do something you are not comfortable with, even if everyone else is doing it."
- "If anyone sends or asks for a picture of you that is private, you can tell me. You will not be in trouble."
- "A crush can be exciting. You can like someone and still say no to things you do not want to do."

AUTISM TIP

- Check the transition plan with the school, including who your young person can go to when they feel overwhelmed.
- Be explicit about hidden social rules such as why people flirt, what a "joke" means and how to tell when someone is not being kind.
- Offer written or visual summaries after a talk. Some young people prefer to read and respond later in writing.
- Plan for sensory challenges in changing rooms and busy corridors.

14 to 18 years: 3rd year to 6th year

Young people are becoming adults. They need accurate information and you in the background as a steady, trusted adult.

What is typical

- Relationships and romantic interests are more serious for many. Others have no interest at all.
- Young people are making choices about alcohol, parties, social events and being away from home.
- Exam pressure, body image and mental health concerns are common.
- They might be using the internet for information about sex, and much of it will be inaccurate or harmful.
- Transition Year, the Leaving Certificate and the Leaving Certificate Applied (LCA) bring new freedoms.

What to teach

- Consent in detail: what it is, how to ask for it, how to notice a "no" that is not spoken, and how alcohol affects choices.
- How to recognise a healthy, unhealthy and abusive relationship.
- Contraception, sexually transmitted infections and where to find accurate information and services.
- The law on consent and on sharing images (see the section on consent and the law).
- How to look after your own safety at parties and events, and how to look after friends.
- Where to go for help, including your GP, helplines and trusted adults.

WORDS TO USE

- "A good relationship is one where both of you feel safe, respected and free to say no."
- "Silence is not consent. Being drunk or asleep is not consent. Consent has to be clear and can be taken back at any time."
- "If you ever need to talk about anything at all, I will not be shocked and I will not be cross."

AUTISM TIP

- Ask directly how your young person would like to learn: talking, reading, a website, a trusted professional.
- Role-play real situations, such as how to leave a party, how to say "no" by text and how to ask someone if they want to kiss.
- Be clear that someone being kind, flattering or interested in them does not always mean they are safe.
- Share lists of services in a written form they can keep.

Puberty planning

Puberty is easiest when it has been planned for. The best time to start is before you think you need to. A good rule is to begin gentle preparation in the middle of primary school, and to be ready sooner if you see early signs.

Start early

- Start the conversation around 3rd or 4th class, or earlier if your child is curious or showing early changes.
- Talk to children of every gender about all of puberty, not only their own. It builds respect and understanding between friends.
- Return to the topic regularly. One conversation is never enough.
- Let your child know that bodies change at different times, and that being early or late is both normal.

Typical changes

Area	What may change	What helps
Body shape and growth	Growth spurts, changes to height, weight and body shape; chest development; broader shoulders or hips	Clothes that fit and feel comfortable; reassurance that every body is different
Hair and skin	Hair under the arms, on the legs, in the pubic area and, for some, on the face; sweating and body odour; spots	A daily washing routine; deodorant; a simple skin care routine
Periods	Periods usually begin a couple of years after the first signs of breast development	A period kit in the school bag; practice with the products; a clear plan for what to do at school
Erections and wet dreams	Erections can happen without warning; wet dreams are common in sleep	Calm information; a plan for changing sheets; privacy
Voice	Voices may deepen or crack	Reassurance that it is temporary
Moods and sleep	Stronger emotions, tiredness, a need for more sleep and more privacy	Predictable routines; time to rest; a quiet place

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Make a visual timeline

A visual timeline shows what will happen and in what order. It turns an unknown into something familiar. You can draw it, use photographs of products, or build one with cards that can be moved around.

1. Draw or print a simple line that shows "now", "soon" and "later".
2. Add changes in the order they usually happen, with a short label and a picture for each.
3. Add a column that says "What I do" for each change, for example "Wash under my arms every day".
4. Leave a space for questions and for dates when your child notices a change.
5. Keep it somewhere private but easy to reach, and add to it as things happen.

Hygiene routines in steps

Hygiene routines are skills. Like any skill, they are learned best when they are broken into small steps, shown, practised and written down. Place the steps near the sink or shower as a picture card.

Routine	Steps (adapt to your child)
Daily wash	1. Turn on the shower and check the temperature. 2. Wet the body and hair. 3. Wash face, then underarms, then private parts, then feet. 4. Rinse. 5. Dry with a towel. 6. Put on clean underwear and clothes.
Deodorant	1. After drying, take the deodorant. 2. Take off the lid. 3. Apply one stripe or a few sprays under each arm. 4. Replace the lid. 5. Wait until it is dry before dressing.
Changing a pad	1. Wash your hands. 2. Take a fresh pad from your kit. 3. Take off the old pad and fold it into the wrapper or paper. 4. Put it in the bin. 5. Put the fresh pad in your underwear, sticky side down. 6. Wash your hands.
Hair washing	1. Wet hair. 2. Put a coin-sized amount of shampoo in your hand. 3. Rub it in with your fingertips. 4. Rinse until the water runs clear. 5. Dry with a towel.
Shaving (if your child chooses)	1. Wet the skin. 2. Apply shaving cream. 3. Shave in the direction of hair growth, slowly. 4. Rinse the razor. 5. Rinse the skin and pat dry. 6. Store the razor safely.

AUTISM TIP

- **Sensory-friendly products:** try unscented or lightly scented soaps. Test deodorants in small amounts: roll-on, stick and spray feel very different. Choose soft, tag-free underwear. Try several pad styles and materials, including washable or period underwear if pads feel uncomfortable. Let your child touch the products before they need them.
- **Predictability:** use the same order and the same equipment each time. Practise on a calm weekend, not before school.
- **Interoception:** some autistic children may not notice the body signals that say "I need the toilet", "I am too hot" or "my pad needs changing". Use timed prompts or phone reminders, and check by routine rather than by feeling.
- **Be literal:** say "every day" or "after PE" rather than "when you need to".

TRY THIS

- Make a puberty kit: pads or period underwear, spare underwear, wet wipes, deodorant, a small bag for used items and a card with your phone number. Practise using it at home first.
- Agree a signal for school: a card to show a teacher or SNA if your child needs to leave the room quietly.
- Talk about privacy at home: knocking, closing the bathroom door and using a bedroom for private things.

Privacy and public places

Puberty is the time to be very clear about what is private and what is public. Teach this in practical terms: which places are private (bedroom, bathroom with the door closed), which are public (kitchen, sitting room, school, the street) and what that means for touching, undressing and talking.

- Give your child a private space and time, so that private behaviour has a private place.
- Show the difference with a simple two-column chart, "Private places" and "Public places".
- Use the same words each time and avoid scolding. Say what to do rather than only what not to do: "If you want to touch yourself, go to your bedroom and close the door."

Keeping children safe

Most adults and young people are kind and safe. Sadly, some children are harmed by someone who has power over them, and that person is often someone the child knows. The

best protection is a child who knows their rights, has the words to describe things and has several adults to turn to.

This section describes patterns at a general level. It is not a checklist for working out who is a risk. If you are ever worried, trust your concern and speak to someone.

Protective behaviours: the two big ideas

Protective behaviours is an approach that gives children two simple messages:

- **We all have the right to feel safe all the time.**
- **Nothing is so awful or so small that we cannot talk about it with someone we trust.**

Teach these in everyday ways, long before you think a child needs them. Use them for little things ("I did not feel safe when the dog barked") as well as for big things. The aim is for a child to know that their feelings are information and that a feeling of being unsafe is worth listening to.

Early warning signs

Our bodies often give us signs when something is not right: a tight tummy, a racing heart, sweaty hands or a wobbly feeling. Help your child to notice theirs and to name them. Many autistic children find body signals hard to read, so use pictures of the body and let your child mark where they feel things.

A network of safe adults

A child should have at least four or five adults they can go to. If one of them is not available, or not the right person, there is always another. A network might include a parent, a grandparent, a family friend, a teacher, an SNA, a GP or a youth leader.

- Help your child to name their safe adults. Draw them on a hand, one adult on each finger.
- Choose people who are reliable, calm and who listen.
- Include at least one person outside the home.
- Tell the adults that they are on the list, so they are ready.
- Review the list every year, and when there are changes in your child's life.
- Use the "My safe adults" template at the end of this guide.

OK touch and not OK touch

Rather than "good touch" and "bad touch", it helps to talk about **OK touch** and **not OK touch**. Some touch feels fine, some feels uncomfortable even when it comes from someone we love, and some is painful or harmful. A child must be able to say how it feels.

Kind of touch	Examples	What a child can do
OK touch	A hug you want, a high five, holding hands crossing the road, a doctor examining you with a parent present	Say yes, accept it or choose another kind such as a wave

Kind of touch	Examples	What a child can do
Not sure	A tickle that goes on too long, a kiss from a relative you do not want to kiss	Say "stop" and have that respected; tell a safe adult how it felt
Not OK touch	Touch to private parts that is not for washing or health; hitting; touch that hurts; touch with a secret	Say no or move away if you can; tell a safe adult; keep telling until someone helps

AUTISM TIP

- Many autistic children have strong views on touch. Some seek deep pressure, others cannot bear light touch. Do not force hugs. Offer a choice ("hug, high five or wave?") and respect it.
- Be explicit about when touch is okay, for example for medical care or help with toileting, and who may do it. Say that the child can always ask why.

Secrets and surprises

Adults often say "Don't tell anyone" about harmless things such as a birthday present. The difference between a harmless surprise and a harmful secret is one of the most important things a child can learn.

Surprises	Secrets that are not okay
Will be told soon, and everyone will be happy	Are meant to be kept for ever
Make people feel excited and happy	Make a person feel worried, scared, sad or confused
Are about nice things such as presents or parties	Involve touch, pictures, threats or being asked not to tell
Nobody is hurt or upset	Come with pressure such as "you'll be in trouble if you tell"

WORDS TO USE

- "In our family we do surprises, but we do not keep secrets. If someone asks you to keep a secret that makes you feel worried or uncomfortable, tell me. You will never be in trouble."

What to watch for

No single sign proves that a child has been harmed. Many of these things have other causes. What matters is a change from what is usual for your child, particularly if several changes happen together or last a long time.

Changes in the child

- Sudden changes in mood, sleep, appetite or toileting habits
- New fears, clinginess, or not wanting to be alone with a particular person or go to a particular place
- Behaviour or knowledge about sex that is not typical for their age
- Regression, such as returning to behaviours from earlier years
- Withdrawal, anxiety, anger or sadness that is new
- Physical signs, such as pain or soreness, that have no clear explanation
- A fall in school attendance or engagement

Patterns in the way an adult or older young person behaves

- Giving a child special attention, gifts or favours that others do not receive
- Seeking time alone with a child and creating ways to be with them privately
- Ignoring boundaries the child or family has set
- Encouraging a child to keep things from parents or carers
- Moving quickly to a close friendship with a child, or making a child feel special or different from others
- Being overly interested in a child's body, a child's online life or a child's secrets

> **AUTISM TIP**
>
> - Autistic children may show distress differently. A meltdown, shutdown, a change in special interests or self-injury can be a way of communicating. Always ask what the behaviour might be telling you.
> - Autistic children may be more trusting, may take words literally and may find it hard to read the intentions of others. This is why explicit teaching and a strong safe-adult network matter so much.
> - Some children cannot easily tell you in words. Offer drawings, picture cards, writing or typing as other ways to tell.

If a child tells you

Being told is a big moment. How you respond will affect whether the child tells again. Children usually tell a little at a time and often test the response first.

1. **Stay calm.** Take a breath. Your face and voice matter.

2. **Listen.** Let the child tell you in their own way and time. Do not press for details or ask leading questions.
3. **Believe them.** Say "I believe you."
4. **Reassure.** Say "It is not your fault" and "I am glad you told me". Say it more than once.
5. **Do not promise secrecy.** Say "I need to tell someone who can help keep you safe". Do not promise something you cannot keep.
6. **Do not confront the person.** This could put the child at more risk and affect any investigation.
7. **Write down** what the child said, in their words, and the date and time as soon as you can.
8. **Get help.** If a child is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. For child-protection concerns, contact Tusla (the Child and Family Agency) or An Garda Síochána. Teachers and SNAs should follow their school's child-protection procedures straight away.
9. **Look after the child, and yourself.** Keep routines steady. Talk to your GP about support for the child and for you. Childline is free on 1800 66 66 66, 24 hours a day.

TRY THIS

- Say: "Thank you for telling me. That was brave. It is not your fault. I am going to get help."
- Avoid: "Are you sure?", "Why did you not say before?" or "Are you making this up?"

Online safety

The online world is part of how children learn, play and make friends. Most online time is positive. Talking early and often keeps the door open for the times when something goes wrong.

The basics for every age

- **Keep devices in shared spaces** for younger children, and agree rules about bedrooms and bedtimes.
- **Use age-appropriate settings,** parental controls and privacy settings on devices, apps and games. They help, but they are not foolproof.
- **Agree what to share** and what to keep private: full name, school, address, location and photos.
- **Talk about who they talk to.** Anyone online may not be who they say they are.
- **Make it safe to tell.** Say clearly: "If anything online upsets or worries you, tell me. You will not lose your device for telling."
- **Learn together.** Ask your child to show you their favourite games and apps.

TRY THIS

- Visit Webwise at webwise.ie for guides, tips and talking points for parents and teachers. It is an Irish online-safety resource.

Sharing images and the law in Ireland

Young people sometimes take, send or ask for intimate pictures. They may do it because of pressure, curiosity, trust or because they think everyone does. A picture can be shared in seconds and cannot be taken back.

In Ireland, sharing or threatening to share intimate images of someone without their consent is a criminal offence under the Harassment, Harmful Communications and Related Offences Act 2020, often called **Coco's Law**.

This is general information, not legal advice. If you need legal advice about a specific situation, speak to a solicitor.

Many young people do not know this. Many do not realise that sending a picture someone has trusted them with can cause lasting harm. Talk about it before it happens.

Points to share with your young person

- Nobody should be pressured, tricked or threatened into sending a picture. It is their right to say no.
- If someone shares or threatens to share a private image, it is not the fault of the person in the picture.
- Once an image is sent, you cannot control where it goes.
- Never forward an image that someone else sent you in trust. It can harm them and may be against the law.
- If it has happened, tell a trusted adult as soon as you can. You will not be in trouble, and there are ways to get help.
- Take screenshots of threats or messages if it is safe to do so, and block the person.

If an image has been shared

1. Stay calm and reassure your child that you are on their side.
2. Do not blame. The person who shared or threatened is the one who did wrong.
3. Save evidence such as usernames, messages and dates. Do not forward the image yourself.
4. Report to the platform and block the account.
5. Illegal content can be reported at Hotline.ie. You can also contact An Garda Síochána.
6. Support your child's wellbeing. Childline (1800 66 66 66) is free and available 24 hours a day.

Pornography and sexual content online

Many children will see sexual content online by accident or because friends show them, and some will search for it out of curiosity. It is more helpful to prepare for this than to hope it will not happen.

Why talk about it

- Online pornography does not show real relationships. It is made to entertain, not to teach.
- It often shows pressure, disrespect or aggression as normal.
- It may leave a child feeling shocked, confused, curious or ashamed.
- Young people tell us they want honest, calm information more than warnings.

How to talk about it calmly

1. Choose a calm moment, perhaps while doing something side by side such as walking or driving.
2. Begin gently: "A lot of young people see sexual videos or pictures online, sometimes by accident. Have you ever seen anything that confused or upset you?"
3. If your child tells you they have seen something, thank them for telling you. Do not punish or shame them.
4. Explain in simple terms: "Those videos are made for entertainment. They are not like real life. Real relationships are about respect, kindness and both people wanting the same thing."
5. Talk about consent: "In real life, people talk to each other and check that both people are happy."
6. Remind them they can always come to you, and that you will not be cross.
7. Review filters, settings and safe search together, and keep checking in.

WORDS TO USE

- "If you see something that makes you uncomfortable, close it or turn it off, and tell me. You are not in trouble."
- "It is normal to be curious. Videos online are not a good way to learn about sex or relationships. Ask me or read this book instead."

AUTISM TIP

- Autistic young people may be very literal and may take what they see as a guide for how to behave. Be clear that online content is not real life, and say specifically what real relationships involve.
- They may fix on a topic or return to a site repeatedly. Explain calmly, offer clear limits and give alternative sources that are accurate.
- Spell out public and private: this content is for adults, in private, and not something we talk about with friends or at school.

Autistic children and young people

Autistic children and young people have the same needs, rights and feelings as anyone else when it comes to bodies, relationships and safety. They need the same information, and they need it in a form that works for them. The barriers are mostly in how information is offered, not in the child.

Why RSE needs adapting

Standard lessons are often built on unwritten assumptions. Many autistic children think and learn differently, so these assumptions can leave gaps. Four common ones are below.

1. Literal understanding

Many autistic children take words at face value. "Hang out", "going out", "getting together", "hooking up" or "private parts" may be baffling or misleading. Phrases like "keep it between us" or "I'm only joking" can be hard to interpret. Say exactly what you mean.

2. Social rules need to be taught openly

Many young people pick up social rules by watching others. Many autistic young people do not, or do so differently. What is polite? How close should I stand? When is a joke not a joke? How do I know if someone likes me? These things need to be taught directly, with examples.

3. Vulnerability to exploitation

Wanting friends and acceptance is human. Autistic young people may be less likely to spot when someone is using friendship to take advantage, may find it hard to say no to someone in authority and may follow instructions exactly. Teach about manipulation in general terms, including that a real friend does not ask you to keep things from your family.

4. Sensory and interoception differences

Interoception is the sense that tells us what is happening inside the body: hunger, thirst, needing the toilet, pain, temperature, emotions and arousal. Differences can make it hard to recognise puberty changes, tell when something feels wrong or know how to describe feelings.

Sensory differences affect washing, clothing, touch, noise in changing rooms and tolerance for products.

> **AUTISM TIP**
>
> None of these are faults. They are differences that can be planned for. When we plan for them, everyone benefits.

Ten practical strategies

1. **Start early and revisit often.** Plan ahead, introduce ideas in small pieces and return to them regularly. Repetition is respect, not a failure.
2. **Use clear, literal language.** Say what you mean. Explain any word that has two meanings and avoid sayings and euphemisms.
3. **Agree the words.** Choose correct names for body parts and a few agreed words for private topics. Keep the same words at home and at school.
4. **Make it visual.** Use diagrams, photographs, timelines, checklists and symbols. Put the steps on a card or in a phone note.
5. **Use social stories and scripts.** Write short stories about what will happen, what is expected and why. Add what the other person may be thinking or feeling.
6. **Rehearse and role-play.** Practise saying no, asking for help and leaving a situation. Practise with a trusted adult before real life.
7. **Prepare for change.** Tell your child what lessons are coming, what will be covered, who will be there and what they can do if they feel overwhelmed.
8. **Build on interests.** Link ideas to the child's special interests when you can. A trains fan may understand "stop" signals and "permission to enter".
9. **Check understanding in different ways.** Allow drawing, writing, typing, pointing or showing. A child who repeats a rule may not yet know how to apply it. Ask "What would you do if...?"
10. **Look after the setting.** Offer a quiet place, fidget tools, breaks and choice about where to sit. Allow for masking, where a child hides their difficulty and appears to understand when they do not.

Public and private

"Public" and "private" are abstract ideas, but they can be taught concretely. Use real places, real people and real behaviours.

	Private	Public
Places	Own bedroom with the door closed; bathroom with the door closed	Kitchen, sitting room, classroom, shop, street, school yard, bus

	Private	Public
Body parts	Parts covered by underwear or swimwear	Hands, face, arms, legs
Behaviours	Undressing, touching your private parts, having a bath or shower	Talking, playing, eating, hugging with permission
People	Doctors and nurses (with a trusted adult present), a carer helping with personal care (with respect)	Everyone else
Talk	Questions about bodies with a trusted adult or in a private place	Talk about hobbies, school and the news

TRY THIS

- Walk around your home with your child and label each room "private" or "public" with a card.
- Use a traffic-light chart: green for behaviours that are fine anywhere, amber for "ask first", red for "private only".

Consent through everyday examples

Consent means freely agreeing, with clear information, to something happening. It starts with small things long before it applies to sex. If children practise it all through childhood, they understand it by the teenage years.

Everyday example	What it teaches
Asking "May I borrow your pencil?" and accepting "no"	We ask before we use what is not ours, and "no" is an answer
Asking "Do you want a hug, a high five or a wave?"	You can choose how you are greeted; other people can too
Asking "Is it okay if I help you with your coat?"	We ask before we touch, even when we are being kind
Allowing a child to say "stop" in a tickling game, and stopping at once	"Stop" always means stop, and adults can be trusted to listen
Knocking before you enter a bedroom or bathroom	Privacy is a right for everyone
Saying "you can change your mind" about a game, a swim or a haircut	Agreeing once does not mean agreeing for ever

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Everyday example	What it teaches
Telling a child what will happen at a medical appointment before it happens	We have a right to information about what happens to our bodies

AUTISM TIP

- Explain that people show "yes" and "no" in many ways, not only with words: moving away, going quiet, looking worried. Practise reading these in pictures and videos.
- Teach that "no" can be said politely and firmly, and that a real friend or partner will respect it.
- Teach that a person can say "yes" and later "no". Agreeing once is not agreeing every time.
- Because some autistic young people find it hard to say no, or to hear a hint, teach that it is the job of the person asking to check, clearly, and to accept a pause or silence as a no.

Diversity: orientation and gender identity

People are different in who they are drawn to and in how they understand their gender. Young people deserve facts, respect and a home where they are loved as they are. This section gives plain, factual information so you can talk about it calmly.

Some useful words

Word	What it means
Sexual orientation	Who a person is romantically or sexually attracted to. This includes people who are attracted to people of a different gender, the same gender, more than one gender or no one.
Gender identity	A person's inner sense of their own gender. It may or may not match the sex they were registered as at birth.
Gender expression	How a person shows their gender, for example through clothes, hair, voice and behaviour.
LGBTQ+	An umbrella term for lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender and queer people, and others whose orientation or identity is not covered by these words.
Asexual	A person who feels little or no sexual attraction. It is a valid orientation.

What to know

- Having a crush on someone, or not having one, is part of growing up. Feelings can be clear to some young people and take time to understand for others.
- Young people usually know whether a parent or carer is a safe person to tell. Your reaction to a television storyline, a news item or a relative's comment shows them what to expect.
- Being LGBTQ+ is not a phase to be tested, a problem to be solved or a result of how a child was raised.
- Young people who are accepted by their families tend to feel safer and happier. Rejection or silence is hard on anyone.
- Your child's identity is theirs to share. Do not tell others without their permission.

How to be supportive

- Use inclusive language from an early age: "When you are older, you might have a partner. That might be a boy, a girl or someone else."
- Include different kinds of families in the books, programmes and examples you choose.
- If your child comes out to you, thank them for trusting you. Say: "I love you. Thank you for telling me." You can ask questions later.
- Use the name and pronouns your child asks you to use, and ask what they would like you to say in front of others.
- Do not demand labels. Some young people are still working things out.
- Challenge teasing and bullying whenever you see it, and ask the school about its policy.

> **WORDS TO USE**
>
> - "There are many kinds of love and many kinds of families. What matters is that people are kind and respectful."
> - "You can talk to me about anything, any time. I will always be on your side."

AUTISM TIP

- Use clear, concrete words and pictures to explain orientation and gender identity. Avoid abstractions and euphemisms.
- If your child is very literal, they may state what they feel directly and without a filter, in front of people. Explain who it is safe and kind to tell, and when. Avoid making them feel ashamed.
- Let your child explore identity in their own way and time, with the support of trusted adults.

TRY THIS

- BeLonG To supports LGBTQ+ young people in Ireland. Share their details with your child if they might find it useful. They also have advice for families.
- If you are struggling with your own feelings, talk to a trusted friend or your GP. Your child needs you steady, and you deserve support too.

Consent, relationships and the law

What consent means

Consent means that a person freely and clearly agrees to something. It has to be given by someone who is able to agree, and it can be withdrawn at any time. In relationships it is a conversation, not a one-off question.

Consent is...	Consent is not...
Freely given, without pressure, threats or tricks	Silence, or someone not saying "no"
Clear: a yes that everyone understands	A yes that was pushed, repeated or bought
Specific: agreeing to one thing does not mean agreeing to everything	A yes to one thing taken as a yes to more
Changeable: a person can stop at any time	Binding because someone said yes before
Possible only when a person is awake, sober and able to choose	Present when a person is asleep, very drunk or unwell

The law in Ireland

The age of consent in Ireland is **17**. That is the age at which the law says a person can agree to sexual activity. Sexual activity with a person under that age is against the law, and the law has more detail than can be covered in a guide for parents.

Sharing, or threatening to share, intimate images without consent is a criminal offence under the Harassment, Harmful Communications and Related Offences Act 2020 (Coco's Law).

This is general information, not legal advice. If you or your child needs legal advice, speak to a solicitor.

Explain the law as a safeguard, not a threat. The point is to protect young people, and to make sure that both people have the information and the maturity to make a decision.

Healthy and unhealthy relationships

Young people often learn about relationships from friends, television and social media, not always from good examples. Talk about what a good relationship looks like and what warning signs to watch for.

Healthy	Unhealthy	Abusive
Feeling safe, respected and free to be yourself	Constant jealousy, checking phones, telling you who you can see	Threats, fear, physical harm or forced sexual activity
Friends and family stay a part of your life	Pressure to spend all your time together	Cutting you off from friends and family
Disagreements are talked through	Putting you down or making fun of you	Humiliating, controlling or hurting you
Both people can say no and it is accepted	Sulking or guilt when you say no	Ignoring your no, or punishing you for it
Both people decide together what to share online	Pushing you to send pictures or share passwords	Threatening to share images or to hurt you

AUTISM TIP

- Use pictures, checklists and real examples. A "Green flags / Red flags" chart on the fridge or a phone note can help.
- Explain that someone who is very nice at the start may still be unkind later. Being flattered is not the same as being respected.
- Teach that you can leave a situation without an explanation. Plan a code word you can text if you need picking up.

Pressure

Pressure may come from a partner, from friends or from the sense that everyone else is doing something. It may be spoken, such as "If you loved me you would", or unspoken, such as the fear of being left out.

- Talk about pressure before it happens. Name it and practise answers.
- Agree an "escape" plan: a code word, a phone call, or a trusted person who will come to collect them with no questions asked.
- Remind your young person that they can say "I am not ready" at any time, and that anyone who cares will accept it.
- Explain that alcohol and drugs affect choices and make it harder to give or notice consent.

WORDS TO USE

- "You can say no, or not yet, to anything at any time, and you never need a reason."
- "If someone keeps asking after you have said no, that is pressure. You are right to leave."

Being ready

There is no right age or right time. Each young person is different, and many decide to wait. Readiness is about much more than the body. It includes being able to talk openly, feeling safe and respected, understanding consent, knowing how to protect health and being ready for the feelings that may follow.

TRY THIS

- Ask: "How would you know if you were ready?" and "What would make you feel safe saying no?"
- Include your values and, if relevant, your faith or ethos, along with the facts. Young people can hold both.

Contraception and sexually transmitted infections: an overview

For parents of older teenagers, the aim is to make sure your young person knows where accurate information is, long before they need it. You do not need to know all the details.

- **Contraception** is used to prevent pregnancy. Different methods work in different ways and suit different people.
- **Condoms** protect against both pregnancy and many sexually transmitted infections (STIs). Other methods do not protect against STIs.

- **STIs** are infections that can pass from one person to another through sexual contact. Many have no symptoms, so testing matters. Many are easily treated.
- **Your GP** can give confidential advice and tell you about local services.
- **sexualwellbeing.ie,** the HSE's sexual health site, has accurate, up-to-date information about contraception, STIs and services.

> **WORDS TO USE**
>
> - "I hope you will wait until you feel ready. If you ever decide to be with someone, I would like you to be safe. You can talk to me, or you can talk to your GP."

RSE in Irish schools

Relationships and Sexuality Education (RSE) in Irish schools is part of the Social, Personal and Health Education (SPHE) curriculum. It is taught alongside what happens at home.

What the NCCA says

- The National Council for Curriculum and Assessment (NCCA) says parents are the primary educators of their children.
- All schools teach the same SPHE curriculum, whatever their ethos.
- Teachers choose the classroom resources and decide the timing to suit their class.

Primary school

- Primary schools teach the 1999 SPHE curriculum.
- The NCCA has an online Primary SPHE Toolkit with supports for teachers.
- SPHE is part of the new Wellbeing area in the Primary Curriculum Framework (2023).
- In early years, Aistear is the framework.

Junior Cycle

- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023) has been taught from 1st year since September 2023.
- It is 100 hours across the three years.
- It has four strands, shown in the table below.

Strand	Title	What it includes (as relevant to this guide)
1	Understanding myself and others	Identity, self-awareness and how we relate to others
2	Making healthy choices	Includes online safety, and why young people share sexual images and the risks of doing so

Strand	Title	What it includes (as relevant to this guide)
3	Relationships and sexuality	Respectful relationships; healthy, unhealthy and abusive relationships; boundaries; reproductive health; sexual orientation and gender identity; pressure; consent (in relationships and in law); safer sex; the influence of popular culture, online content and pornography; trustworthy supports
4	Emotional wellbeing	Feelings, coping and looking after mental health

Senior Cycle

- A new Senior Cycle SPHE specification was published in October 2024.
- Schools are to introduce it for 5th years by September 2027.
- In the Leaving Certificate Applied (LCA), it replaces Social Education Modules I and II from 2025.

Guidance for children with special educational needs

The NCCA has guidance on RSE for children with special educational needs. It stresses these approaches, and they work for many children, including autistic children:

- Differentiate lessons and revisit topics often.
- Plan early and pre-teach vocabulary, especially before puberty.
- Give consistent messages across the whole school.
- Use multi-sensory methods and inclusive resources.
- Agree the correct names for body parts.
- Involve children and parents, with a real partnership between home and school.
- Model consent and protect dignity in personal care.
- Put safeguards in place against bullying and exploitation.
- Allow different ways to show understanding, and allow for masking.

Working with your child's school

- **Ask early.** Ask when RSE topics are taught and what resources are used. Do this at the start of the year.
- **Share what works.** Tell the school about your child's agreed words, visuals and sensory needs.
- **Pre-teach at home.** Ask for outlines of lessons so that you can read vocabulary or watch a video beforehand.
- **Make a plan with the right people.** This may include the class teacher, the SET, the SNA and the principal.

- **Stay in touch.** Ask how your child reacted and whether any concerns came up.
- **Check the policy.** Ask to see the school's RSE policy and child-protection procedures.
- **Keep it constructive.** Teachers want what is best for your child. A calm partnership gets the best results.

> **TRY THIS**
>
> - Teachers and SNAs: ask families what words they use at home and use the same ones. Send home a short note before lessons so that families can prepare.
> - Offer alternative ways for students to ask questions, such as a question box or written notes.

Questions to ask the school

- How and when will RSE be taught this year, and by whom?
- Which resources will be used? Can I see them?
- How will you pre-teach vocabulary and prepare my child for lessons?
- How will my child's needs be supported during lessons, for example visuals, breaks and sensory supports?
- What happens if my child asks a question or is upset?
- How will you support my child with puberty and personal care?
- How do you protect children from bullying and exploitation?
- How do you work with parents, and who is my contact?
- What is the school's policy on RSE and child protection?

There is a template at the end of this guide for writing your own list.

Tips for talking

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Fifteen tips

1. **Start before you feel ready.** There is no perfect time. Starting small is better than waiting.
2. **Stay calm.** A relaxed voice tells your child that this is a normal subject.
3. **Use correct words.** Plain, accurate words remove mystery and shame.
4. **Keep it short.** A few sentences, then stop. Let your child ask more.
5. **Listen first.** Ask "What have you heard?" before you answer. You may find that they know less, or more, than you thought.
6. **Answer the question being asked.** A small question usually needs a small answer.
7. **Say it is okay to ask.** Tell your child often that questions are welcome.

8. **Be honest.** If you do not know something, say so and find out together.
9. **Say "I will get back to you" if you need time.** Then do.
10. **Talk side by side.** Many people find it easier when they are walking, drawing, cooking or driving, and not face to face.
11. **Use books and other resources.** A good book can say what you find hard to say. Leave books where your child can find them privately.
12. **Do not mock or tease.** Embarrassment ends conversations.
13. **Share your values and explain why.** Young people will respect your views more when they understand the reasons, even if they disagree.
14. **Repeat yourself.** Children need to hear things many times. This is not nagging.
15. **Look after yourself.** If these conversations stir up your own memories or worries, talk to a friend, your GP or a support service.

Conversation starters by age

Age	You could say or ask
Under 5	"Let's see what you are going to wear today. Which part of your body is your knee? Which is your elbow?" "Who are the grown-ups you can tell if you feel worried?"
5 to 9	"That programme had a baby in it. Do you have any questions about how babies grow?" "What do you do if a friend asks you to do something you do not want to do?"
9 to 12	"Some children your age start noticing changes in their bodies. Would you like a book about it?" "What would you do if someone sent you something online that you did not like?"
12 to 14	"What do people in your year say about relationships? Is it like that, do you think?" "How would you know if a friend was being pressured?"
14 to 18	"What do you think makes a good relationship?" "If a friend told you they were being pressured to send a photo, what would you advise?" "Is there anything you would like to know more about?"

What if they will not talk?

Some children and young people are shy, private or do not have the words yet. Some find talking hard in general. Silence does not mean that they are not listening or not interested.

- **Keep going.** Keep offering, even when they say nothing. They hear you.
- **Offer another route.** Let them write, text, draw, type, use a question box or use a diary that you both read.

- **Use a third party.** A trusted aunt, uncle, grandparent, GP, youth worker or teacher may be easier to talk to.
- **Use media.** Watch a programme together, then talk about the characters rather than your child.
- **Talk about "people" and not "you".** "Some young people feel pressure about.." is easier to respond to than "Do you feel pressure about..?"
- **Give time.** Leave a gap and do not fill it. Some children need many seconds to answer.
- **Keep the door open.** End with: "If you ever want to talk about this, you can find me any time."
- **Seek help if you are worried.** If a change in behaviour worries you, speak to your GP or the school.

AUTISM TIP

- Some autistic children find eye contact and open-ended questions very difficult. Use closed questions, choices or a scale. For example, "Would you like to read about this or talk about it?" or "On a scale of 1 to 5, how worried are you?"
- Allow a special interest or an object in hand during the conversation.
- Give time to process. Waiting 10 seconds is not too long.

Supports and services in Ireland

You do not have to do this alone. These supports are available in Ireland. Check the websites for the most up-to-date details.

Service	What it offers	How to reach it
Childline	Free, confidential support for children and young people, 24 hours a day	1800 66 66 66
Emergency services	If a child or anyone is in immediate danger	112 or 999
Tusla, the Child and Family Agency	Contact if you have a concern about a child's safety or welfare	Search for Tusla online
An Garda Síochána	To report a crime or a concern about a child's safety	Your local Garda station, or 112 / 999 in an emergency
Webwise	Online safety advice and resources for parents, teachers and young people	webwise.ie
Hotline.ie	To report illegal content online	hotline.ie

Service	What it offers	How to reach it
HSE sexualwellbeing.ie	Accurate information about sexual health, contraception, STIs and relationships	sexualwellbeing.ie
Dublin Rape Crisis Centre national helpline	National helpline for anyone affected by sexual violence	1800 77 88 88
Women's Aid	Support relating to domestic abuse	1800 341 900
BeLonG To	Support for LGBTQ+ young people and their families	Search for BeLonG To online
Your GP	Confidential advice on health, development, contraception and referrals	Your local GP practice
Autism & Me	Neuroinclusive education consultancy; questions about this guide	contactautismandme@gmail.com | www.autismandme.ie

TRY THIS

- Save the numbers that matter in your phone and your child's phone.
- Put Childline's number somewhere your child can see it: on the fridge, in the school bag or as a contact.

This guide is general information and is not a substitute for professional advice. If you are worried about a child, contact the services above.

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Templates you can edit

Print these pages, or type straight into the tables on screen. Share them with your child's school, grandparents or carers so that everyone uses the same words.

Template 1: Our agreed words

List the words your family will use for body parts, body processes and private topics. Agree on the same words at home and at school.

Body part or topic	Our agreed word	Notes (who uses it, where)	Picture or symbol

Template 2: My safe adults

Draw a hand or write a name beside each finger. Choose adults your child trusts and who are easy to reach. Include at least one person outside the home.

Safe adult	Relationship	How I contact them	Agreed that they know they are on my list

Safe adult	Relationship	How I contact them	Agreed that they know they are on my list

Review this list each year or whenever there is a change.

Template 3: Questions I want to ask the school

Question	Who I will ask	Date asked	Answer or action

Template 4: Puberty plan

Fill this in with your child. Use pictures where they help.

Change or topic	When we will talk about it	What I will say and show	Products or supports needed	Done

Change or topic	When we will talk about it	What I will say and show	Products or supports needed	Done

Hygiene routine checklist

Step	Picture	Morning	Evening	After PE

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